SPERT® Story Map: Connect AI

Pair a compatible AI assistant with your story map to build and edit structure in real time · storymap.spertsuite.com

WHAT IS CONNECT AI?

Connect AI is a feature in SPERT® Story Map that lets a compatible AI assistant build or edit your story map in real time. When the connection is active, the AI can build an entire map structure — themes, backbones, and rib items — from a single description, or create them one at a time; organize work into releases, size unsized rib items on explicit request, re-plan by reassigning rib items between releases, move rib items to a different backbone (or reorganize many at once), and enrich rib cards with descriptions, notes, and acceptance criteria — all changes appear on your map as the AI works. You stay in control at every step: the AI asks what you want to build before doing anything, and you choose exactly what it can access.

Connect AI works through the **MCP protocol** (Model Context Protocol) — a standard for giving AI assistants access to external tools. SPERT Story Map hosts a dedicated MCP server at mcp.spertsuite.com that the AI calls to read and write your map structure. The AI assistant must be configured to reach this server before the feature can be used.

HOW IT WORKS — EACH SESSION

#	Action	Detail
1	Open a project and click Connect AI	The Connect AI button is in the project header, next to your product name. A consent modal appears.
2	Choose permissions	**Write Mode** (required) — the AI can create and edit themes, backbones, rib items, releases, rib sizes, release allocations, and rib descriptions, categories, and notes, and can move rib items to a different backbone. **Read Mode** (optional) — the AI can see your current map structure, release assignments, and rib sizes before making changes. Read Mode is required when asking the AI to allocate, unassign, or size ribs, update rib text fields in bulk, move rib items between backbones, or re-plan an existing map. Click **Connect**.
3	Copy the pairing code and prompt	A short pairing code (e.g., CRANE-7842) appears alongside two copy buttons: **Copy Code** (the code alone) and **Copy Prompt** (a ready-to-paste message that includes the code and detailed instructions for the AI). The code expires in 15 minutes.
4	Paste the prompt into your AI assistant	Open your AI assistant — it must already be configured with the SPERT MCP server (see One-Time Setup). Paste the copied prompt and send it. The assistant will call the MCP server to claim the session, then ask you what product you are planning and which story map structure fits best before building anything.
5	Review and disconnect	Themes, backbones, rib items, release assignments, and sizes appear on your map in real time. Use Ctrl+Z to undo any AI action. Toggle **Read Mode** on or off from the Connect AI panel at any time. Click **Disconnect** when you are done — or the session expires automatically after 7 days.

Note: Do not switch projects while the AI is actively building — Connect AI is scoped to the project that was open when you clicked Connect. Rib items with sprint progress cannot be resized by either the AI or the Sizing board, and the AI cannot reassign their release. To resize a locked rib or change its release, clear its progress first. A locked rib **can** still be moved to a different backbone by the AI — that part of a move never touches progress data.

ONE-TIME SETUP: CONNECT YOUR AI CLIENT

Connect AI requires an AI client that supports MCP servers. Complete this setup once; every subsequent session starts at step 1 above. Seven clients work today. **For large maps or bulk changes, use ChatGPT or Claude** — they handle big batch operations in a single request. **For large enrichment tasks** (adding descriptions, notes, and acceptance criteria to many cards at once), **Claude is the most reliable choice**. Any connected assistant works well for small, targeted edits.

claude.ai web (Pro / Max / Team / Enterprise)	Lowest-friction path for non-developers — no terminal or config file required. Free-tier accounts are not supported. In claude.ai, go to **Settings** → **Connectors** → **Add custom connector**. Paste the server URL: https://mcp.spertsuite.com No API key is needed — click Save. To use it: open a new conversation, confirm the SPERT connector is active, open SPERT Story Map in your browser, click Connect AI, and paste the Copy Prompt.
Claude Code (CLI, any plan)	Best for developers — one command. Run once in any terminal: `claude mcp add --transport http spert-suite https://mcp.spertsuite.com` Add `--scope user` to make the server available across all projects (default is project-scope only). Confirm with `claude mcp list` — you should see spert-suite in the output. To use it: start a Claude Code session, open SPERT Story Map, click Connect AI, and paste the Copy Prompt.
Claude Desktop (config file)	Requires Node.js (for npx). Locate the config file: on macOS, `~/Library/Application Support/Claude/claude_desktop_config.json`; on Windows, `%APPDATA%\Claude\claude_desktop_config.json`. Add the following to the **mcpServers** object (create the file if it does not exist): `"spert-suite": { "command": "npx", "args": ["mcp-remote", "https://mcp.spertsuite.com"] }` Save the file and restart Claude Desktop. mcp-remote installs automatically on first run.
Grok (paid tiers)	Self-service on all paid Grok tiers — similar UX to claude.ai Connectors. Go to grok.com/connectors → **New Connector** → **Custom** → paste https://mcp.spertsuite.com. No authentication required — click Create. To use it: open a Grok conversation, open SPERT Story Map in your browser, click Connect AI, and paste the Copy Prompt.
ChatGPT (Pro / Team / Enterprise / Edu, Developer Mode)	Requires Developer Mode to be enabled. On **Pro** plans, go to **Settings** → **Apps & Connectors** → **Advanced** → **Developer Mode** → **On**. On **Business / Enterprise / Edu** plans, a workspace admin must enable it from Workspace Settings → Permissions & Roles → Connected Data. Once enabled, add the server: click **+** in a conversation → More → paste https://mcp.spertsuite.com, no authentication. To use it: open SPERT Story Map in your browser, click Connect AI, and paste the Copy Prompt into the ChatGPT conversation. **Recommended for large maps, bulk release planning, and allocation** — confirmed to build a 50-story map with releases and full allocation in a single request. **Note:** For large enrichment tasks (many descriptions and notes), Claude is more reliable — ChatGPT may pause for confirmation between steps. If ChatGPT shows fewer tools than expected or behaves unexpectedly, check that you are on a capable model tier; free-tier model downgrades can cause tool enumeration issues.
Copilot Studio (Microsoft 365, advanced)	In a Copilot Studio agent, go to **Tools** → **New tool** → **Model Context Protocol**, paste https://mcp.spertsuite.com, set Authentication to **None**, and click Create. Use the agent's Test panel to interact. Requires a Microsoft 365 license. **Note on Microsoft 365 Copilot Chat (the standard chat experience):** Copilot Chat connects and works well for small, targeted edits — including moving one rib item at a time — but struggles with bulk changes on large maps — it may stall partway through or return an error on batch operations. For a big reorganization (many releases, many allocations, or redistributing many rib items across backbones), use ChatGPT or Claude instead. Copilot Studio (this row) is a stronger orchestrator than Copilot Chat and handles larger operations; it requires additional admin configuration to deploy to Copilot Chat.
Gemini CLI (developer path)	Google's command-line AI tool supports MCP via a config file, similar to Claude Code. Add the SPERT server to your Gemini CLI settings file under the **mcpServers** key with the server URL https://mcp.spertsuite.com. To use it: start a Gemini CLI session, open SPERT Story Map, click Connect AI, and paste the Copy Prompt.

Choosing the right assistant for the job: Claude (claude.ai, Claude Code, Claude Desktop) is the most reliable choice for large enrichment tasks — adding descriptions, notes, and acceptance criteria to many cards at once. Confirmed: 100-rib map enriched in one pass with Claude Code. **ChatGPT and Claude** both handle bulk structural changes well — creating many releases, allocating dozens of stories, redistributing many rib items across backbones, or re-planning a large map in a single request. **Microsoft 365 Copilot Chat** is great for quick, targeted edits (add a rib, rename a theme, move a single rib item) but may stall or return an error on large batch operations. For a big reorganization with Copilot, switch to ChatGPT or Claude. **Grok and Copilot Studio** connect and work; bulk performance on large maps is best confirmed with a short test run on your own account.

WHAT STILL DOESN'T WORK

Connect AI requires an AI client with MCP server support configured. If you paste the Copy Prompt into an AI that has no MCP connection, the assistant reads the tool-call instructions but has no actual channel to your story map — nothing changes in the app. In some cases the AI may even fabricate a response, describing a map it claims to have built. The tell: tool names like **resolve_session_code** appear in the reply, but your map stays empty.

Not supported today: Gemini web app (gemini.google.com) — no self-service custom MCP connector in the consumer interface yet (Gemini CLI works; the web app does not). Free-tier claude.ai accounts — Connectors require a paid plan. ChatGPT Free and Plus without Developer Mode enabled. Any other AI assistant without MCP support configured.

WHAT'S COMING

MCP adoption has moved quickly. Seven clients work today: Claude (claude.ai, Code, Desktop), ChatGPT, Grok, Copilot Studio, and Gemini CLI. The remaining gap for consumer users is the Gemini web app — there is no self-service custom MCP connector in the consumer Gemini web interface yet, though Gemini CLI works for developers via a config file.

As MCP adoption continues to expand, Connect AI will work with new clients automatically — no changes to the SPERT server or your workflow will be required. The same pairing-code workflow works across all supported clients today.

WRITE MODE, READ MODE & PRIVACY

Write Mode (required)	Lets the AI create themes, backbones, and rib items, organize work into releases, size unsized rib items on explicit request, re-plan by unassigning and reallocating rib items between releases, move rib items to a different backbone (optionally reassigning the release in the same step), and update rib descriptions, categories, and notes in bulk. Six bulk tools collapse N individual calls into one for an existing map — critical for large maps and AI clients that yield between tool calls: **storymap_bulk_create_releases**, **storymap_bulk_allocate**, **storymap_bulk_size**, **storymap_bulk_unassign**, **storymap_bulk_update_ribs**, and **storymap_bulk_move_ribs**. A seventh, **storymap_bulk_import**, is a fast path for the AI to build a brand-new map structure in one call instead of one theme/backbone/rib at a time (21 tools total). The AI cannot delete items or modify progress data. Rib items with sprint progress cannot be resized by the AI or the Sizing board, and the AI cannot reassign their release — clear progress first to unlock. Rib items with sprint progress **can** still have their backbone changed, and their descriptions, categories, and notes updated, by the AI.
Read Mode (optional)	Shares a compact snapshot of your current map with the AI — structure, release assignments, current rib sizes, size mapping, and rib descriptions. No progress data, allocation percentages, assessment notes, or rib item notes are included in the snapshot. The snapshot does flag whether a rib's release allocation is a partial percentage, so the AI can warn you before a move silently skips reassigning it. Read Mode is required when asking the AI to allocate or unassign ribs, size existing ribs, update rib text fields in bulk, move rib items between backbones, or re-plan release assignments; leave it off when building from scratch. Toggle at any time from the Connect AI session panel. **Note on rib notes:** the AI can write notes to rib cards, but notes are not returned by the snapshot — to verify notes were applied, open the rib card's detail panel.

Session data & expiry	Pairing codes are single-use and expire after 15 minutes. Session data (the ops queue and any Read Mode snapshot) is stored in Firebase and auto-purged after 7 days. Click Disconnect to end a session and delete the snapshot immediately. Full details at spertsuite.com/ai-privacy.
AI-built map limits	A single Connect AI session can build up to 5 themes, 10 backbones per theme, and 10 rib items per backbone — up to 500 rib items total. These limits apply only to AI-assisted building; the standard app has no structural size limits. Bulk operations handle up to 500 rib items per call and up to 50 releases per call. Existing maps and all other editing tools are otherwise unchanged.
Tips & caveats	Enable Read Mode before asking the AI to edit an existing map, allocate work to releases, unassign or reassign rib items, move rib items between backbones, update rib text fields in bulk, or size ribs — without it, the AI cannot see your current structure and may duplicate work. Undo (Ctrl+Z) works on all AI-generated content. Review the AI's output before saving a JSON backup, as Undo history resets on page refresh. Don't switch projects mid-session; Connect AI is scoped to the project open at the time you clicked Connect. The AI never deletes themes, backbones, rib items, or releases — only you can delete. When the AI updates rib notes, verify them by opening the rib card's detail panel — notes are not shown in the snapshot returned by **storymap_get_project**. Moving rib items between backbones may reorder them within their release's column on the Release Planning board, even when the release itself didn't change — a cosmetic side effect, not a data change.

ENRICHING RIB CARDS WITH THE AI

Once your story map structure exists — themes, backbones, and rib items — you can ask the AI to enrich the rib cards with descriptions, acceptance criteria, and implementation notes. This is done with the **storymap_bulk_update_ribs** tool, which updates up to 500 rib cards in a single call. Enable **Read Mode** first so the AI can read your map structure.

Example prompts that work well:

Add descriptions	"Read Mode is on. For each rib item in the map, write a 1–2 sentence description that explains what the feature does and who it benefits."
Add acceptance criteria	"For each rib item, add acceptance criteria in the Notes field. Use a simple Given/When/Then format. Keep each criterion to 2–3 lines."
Enrich a specific backbone	"Look at the rib items under the 'User Authentication' backbone and add detailed notes covering edge cases, dependencies, and any security considerations."
Clear all notes	"Remove the Notes content from every rib item in the map." (The AI will set each notes field to empty — this is reversible with Ctrl+Z.)

Note on rib notes: The AI can write notes to rib cards, but notes are not included in the map snapshot returned by **storymap_get_project**. To verify notes were applied, open the rib card's detail panel in the app. Descriptions and categories are included in the snapshot and can be verified by asking the AI to read the map again.

MOVING RIB ITEMS WITH THE AI

Once your story map has backbones and releases in place, you can ask the AI to move rib items — relocate a card to a different backbone, reassign its release, or both in the same request. This uses **storymap_move_rib** for a single card or **storymap_bulk_move_ribs** to redistribute many cards in one call — for example, splitting every rib item under one backbone across several new ones. Enable **Read Mode** first so the AI can see your current structure.

Example prompts that work well:

Move one rib to a new backbone	"Move the 'Reset password' rib item to the 'Account Recovery' backbone."

Redistribute many ribs at once	"Look at every rib item under the 'Legacy Checkout' backbone. Decide which of the new backbones — 'Cart', 'Payment', or 'Fulfillment' — each one fits best, and move it there."
Move and reassign the release together	"Move the 'Add to cart' rib item to the 'Cart' backbone and allocate it to the 'v2.1' release."
Reorganize the whole map	"Create backbones that reflect the actual feature areas in this product, then move every rib item into the backbone it best fits." (Best with ChatGPT or Claude on a large map — see Choosing the right assistant, above.)

Locked rib items: a rib item with recorded sprint progress can still be moved to a different backbone by the AI. Only the release-reassignment part of a move is blocked on a locked rib — clear its progress first if you also need to change its release.

Split or partial release allocations: if a rib item's release doesn't change after asking the AI to move it, check whether that rib was split across multiple releases or partially allocated (under 100%) to one. The AI skips the release change on these rib items on purpose, so it never silently overwrites a percentage you set by hand. To replace a split or partial allocation, ask the AI to unassign the rib item first, then move it — an unassigned rib is always eligible for a new release.

Good to know: the target backbone for a move can be in any theme, not just the rib's current one — useful if you keep more than one theme on a map. Moving rib items between backbones may also reorder them within their (unchanged) release's column on the Release Planning board — a cosmetic side effect of the move, not a bug. For a large reorganization, prefer asking for it in one request (**storymap_bulk_move_ribs**) over moving items one at a time — it completes in a single step and is more reliable on AI clients that pause between tool calls, such as Microsoft 365 Copilot Chat.

TROUBLESHOOTING

Symptom	Likely cause	Fix
AI shows fewer tools than expected (e.g. only 3 tools, or missing bulk tools)	Stale cached manifest. AI clients cache the tool list at connect time.	Fully remove the MCP connector and re-add it. A soft Refresh is often insufficient. After re-adding, confirm the connector lists ~21 tools before starting a session.
ChatGPT behaves unexpectedly: loops, does not follow instructions, or reports few tools	Free-tier model downgrade. Token exhaustion can silently drop ChatGPT to a weaker model.	Start a new conversation. Confirm you are on a capable model tier (GPT-4o or equivalent). With the capable model, all 21 tools enumerate correctly and bulk operations complete in one pass.
Tool names appear in the AI's reply but nothing changes in the app	The AI has no live MCP connection — it is reading the prompt but cannot reach the server.	The AI assistant must be configured with the SPERT MCP server (see One-Time Setup). Paste the Copy Prompt only after the connector is set up. Tool names in a reply without any actual changes is the classic sign of a missing connection.
appVersion shows an old version number after a deploy	Browser tab is using a cached JS bundle from before the deploy.	Open a new browser tab (do not reuse a tab opened before the deploy). Create a fresh Connect AI session in the new tab.

AI updates descriptions but notes appear empty after storymap_get_project	Notes are write-only in the map snapshot by design.	Notes are not returned by storymap_get_project. Open the rib card's detail panel in the app to verify notes content. Descriptions and categories are in the snapshot and can be read back normally.
Rib item cannot be resized by AI	Rib is locked — it has recorded sprint progress (> 0%).	Locked ribs cannot be resized by the AI or the Sizing board. Clear the rib's progress data first to unlock it. Note: descriptions, categories, and notes can still be updated on locked ribs, and a locked rib can still be moved to a different backbone.
Moving a rib item doesn't change its release (backbone move still works)	The rib's release allocation is a split or under 100% (partial).	The AI intentionally skips the release change on a split or partially-allocated rib item, so it never overwrites a percentage you set by hand. Ask the AI to unassign the rib item first, then move it again — an unassigned rib is eligible for the new release.
Rib items appear in a different order on the Release Planning board after an AI move	Moving a rib between backbones repositions it within its release's column as a side effect.	This is a cosmetic side effect of the move — no release or progress data changed. Drag the card back into place on the Release Planning board if you'd like a different order.